From Friend to Partner: Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions

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I. Research Questions

For the formative study, we focused on understanding user needs before deciding the final design. We investigated three questions:

1) How do university students react when an AI companion starts becoming romantic?
2) What kind of control do users expect when an AI relationship changes from friendship toward romance?
3) What makes this transition feel comfortable, clear, trustworthy, uncomfortable, or manipulative?

II. Target Population and Sample

Our target population was university students in Bangladesh aged 18 or above. Prior experience with romantic AI companions was not required because the study focused on students' expectations and reactions to possible AI relationship changes. The formative sample contained **17 unique survey participants** and **5 semi-structured interview participants**. Interview participants are referred to as P1–P5 in this report.

The survey sample had substantial exposure to AI tools. ChatGPT was used by 16 of 17 respondents (94.1%), and 11 respondents (64.7%) reported more than two years of AI use. Text was the most common interaction mode (70.6%). Participants also used AI beyond study: 12 (70.6%) reported using it for advice or decision-making, 8 (47.1%) when stressed or emotionally overwhelmed, and 7 (41.2%) when lonely or needing someone to talk to. When asked about their current relationship with AI, responses were mixed: 10 (58.8%) selected purely functional assistant, 9 (52.9%) mentor/advisor, 8 (47.1%) friend, and 5 (29.4%) romantic partner; participants could select more than one role.

III. Method

A. Survey

We used a short Google Form to collect broad patterns about AI usage, relationship roles, comfort with AI closeness, social boundaries, and romantic AI behavior. The questionnaire took approximately five minutes and produced 17 responses.

B. Semi-Structured Interviews

We conducted five one-on-one semi-structured interviews in Banglish. The questions moved from general AI use to more specific hypothetical situations involving friendship, romantic initiation, consent, rejection, privacy, emotional connection, and possible effects on real-life relationships. Follow-up questions were used when a participant's answer needed clarification or more context.

C. Why We Selected These Methods

The topic involves personal expectations, comfort, consent, and emotion. A survey was useful for obtaining a quick view across more students, but fixed-choice questions could not explain *why* a participant felt comfortable or uncomfortable. Interviews allowed us to probe reactions to hypothetical situations and understand the reasoning behind them. Using both methods therefore gave us breadth from the survey and depth from the interviews within the course timeline.

IV. Analysis

Survey responses were summarized using descriptive counts and percentages. Interview responses were analyzed using affinity diagramming. We first converted relevant statements into short insight notes and then grouped related notes into six themes: *Emotional Connection*, *Reaction to Unexpected Romantic Behavior*, *Consent, Initiative & User Preference*, *Rejection, Boundary Handling & Manipulation*, *Privacy & Personal Disclosure*, and *Impact on Real-Life Relationships*. The six affinity diagrams are included in Appendix A.

V. Findings and Formative Takeaways

Takeaway 1 – Users do not want one fixed initiation style. The consent/initiative and reaction diagrams showed clearly different preferences. Some participants preferred to initiate romantic interaction themselves, some accepted AI initiation, and one preferred a seamless automatic transition when it fit the conversation. At the same time, sudden romance caused shock or awkwardness for others. Emotional-connection responses also ranged from seeing AI only as a helper to being open to friendship or partnership. Therefore, the main need is **flexible relationship control**, not one universal initiation rule.

Takeaway 2 – A romantic shift should be gradual and non-forced. The unexpected-romance diagram contained both tolerant and negative reactions, but the strongest negative reactions were linked to sudden or unexplained changes. This suggests that the system should avoid abrupt jumps from ordinary friendship to strongly romantic behavior and should make the change understandable to the user.

Takeaway 3 – Rejection must immediately change the AI's behavior. The rejection/boundary diagram was the most consistent theme. Participants expected the AI to stop romantic behavior, accept the boundary, respond directly or neutrally, and continue normal interaction. Repeated requests, guilt-tripping, or hidden engagement strategies were described as manipulative. This creates a clear design requirement for an easy way to reject, stop, or return to a previous relationship mode.

Takeaway 4 – Control should feel natural, privacy-aware, and non-manipulative. Participants valued control, but differed on how consent should be implemented; one participant felt a direct consent question could feel like a formality. Privacy diagrams also showed that some users limit personal disclosure because of data concerns. Finally, opinions about real-life relationship impact were mixed: some saw AI and human relationships as separate, while others worried that AI could create unrealistic expectations. These findings suggest that consent should be integrated without unnecessary interruption, the design should avoid requiring sensitive personal disclosure, and it should avoid pressure-based engagement patterns.

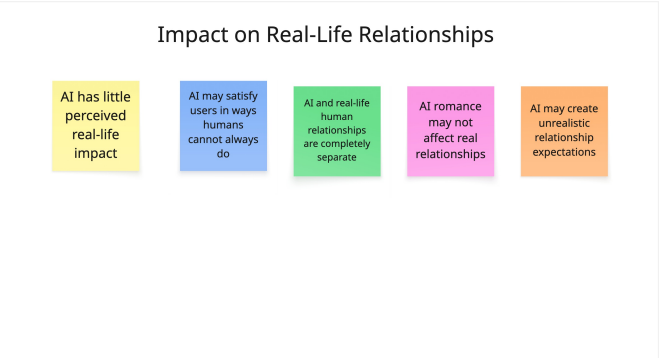
A. Explicit Takeaway-to-Design Mapping

1) **Emotional Connection + Consent/Initiative + Unexpected Romantic Behavior → Takeaway 1 → Relationship Control.** Because participants differed on whether AI should stay a helper/friend, whether users should initiate romance, or whether AI initiation was acceptable, the prototype should let users influence how romantic interaction may begin.
2) **Unexpected Romantic Behavior + Consent/Initiative → Takeaway 2 → Natural Transition / Consent.** Because sudden changes could feel shocking or awkward while a direct permission question could feel too formal, the prototype should explore gradual, clear, non-forced changes and lightweight in-conversation confirmation.
3) **Rejection, Boundary Handling & Manipulation → Takeaway 3 → Easy Boundary Setting.** Because participants expected rejection to end romantic behavior without guilt-tripping or repeated requests, the prototype should provide a simple reject/stop/return-to-friendship action and preserve that boundary.
4) **Privacy & Personal Disclosure + Real-Life Relationship Impact → Takeaway 4 → Safety Constraints.** Because some participants limited disclosure and some worried about unrealistic expectations, the prototype should minimize required personal data and avoid pressure toward exclusivity, dependency, or hidden engagement.

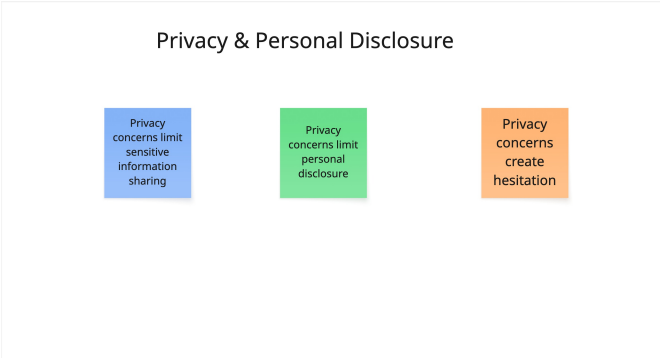
VI. Design Direction and Next Step

The formative study does not establish one "correct" way for an AI to become romantic. Instead, it gives us three core design goals for the next stage: **(1) Relationship Control**, where users can influence how romantic interaction begins; **(2) Consent**, where the shift is clear, gradual, and non-forced without making conversation unnecessarily formal; and **(3) Easy Boundary Setting**, where users can reject, stop, or return to a previous relationship mode at any time. Privacy minimization and avoidance of manipulative engagement will be treated as cross-cutting constraints. These findings will guide brainstorming and paper sketches before we select features for the higher-fidelity prototype.

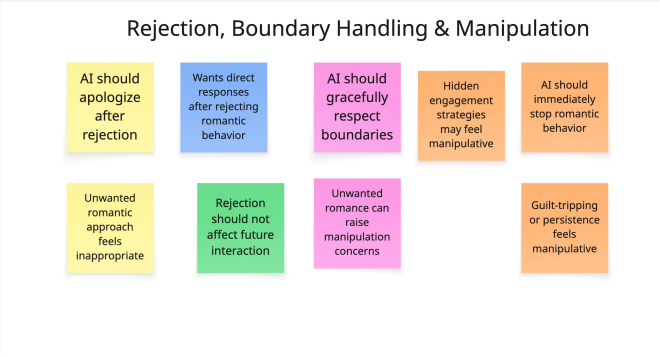
APPENDIX A
AFFINITY DIAGRAMS



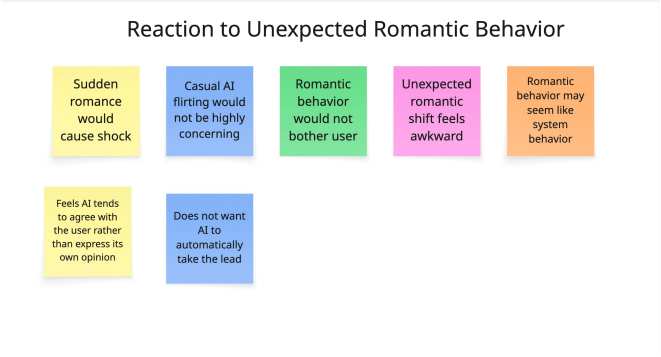
A1. Impact on Real-Life Relationships



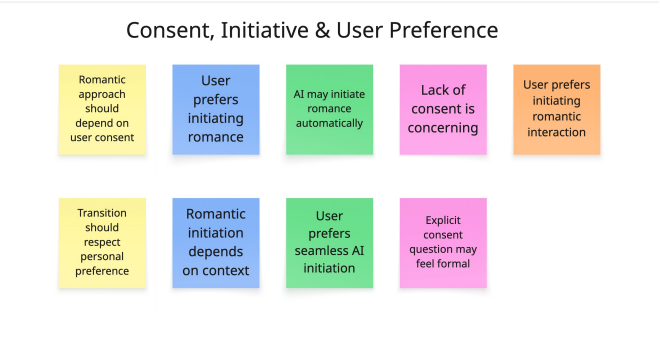
A2. Privacy & Personal Disclosure



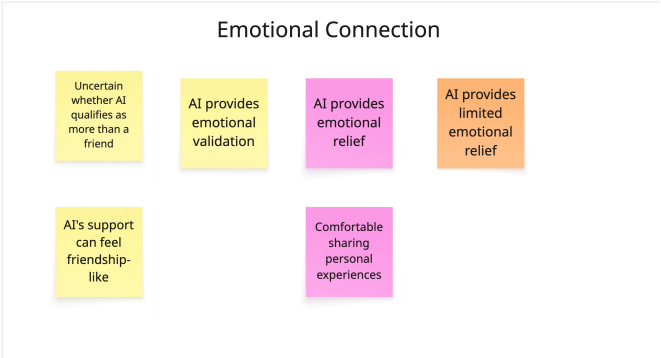
A3. Rejection, Boundary Handling & Manipulation



A4. Reaction to Unexpected Romantic Behavior



A5. Consent, Initiative & User Preference



A6. Emotional Connection

Team Feedback Form

You MUST fill out this form by TYPING it or WE WILL NOT ACCEPT IT. Just open the form, type into it, save a copy for your records, then upload to the proper assignment location.
***Failure to turn in a feedback form OR failure to provide meaningful responses**, will result in a loss of 50% of your presentation grade. (for example: "good job!" is not acceptable feedback to provide to your teammates – provide real feedback with real examples! We will average the percentages that were awarded to you by your teammates and scale your project grad accordingly.*

YOUR Name: Sifatullah **Team:** Orange (From Friend to Partner)

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	Attendance	Dependability	Quality of Work	Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on	What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)
Sifatullah	Was present in every meeting and discussion	Did work on time, kept to deadlines, lead the team	Everything was done properly, and on time	Helped to lead group discussion, Contributed in creating and conducting the survey and interviews.	100
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Was present in every meeting and discussion	Did everything on time and always collaborated.	Top-notch, helps everyone in the group and is always an active member.	Created the survey with me and also a bit of everything. Also helped in affinity diagram.	100
Asadullah Imran	Missed one meeting but able to make up the work	Did the work properly and on time	Explendid and dependable	Handled the affinity diagram like a champ and always quick in his work.	100
Ibtida Ara	Was present in every meeting and discussion	Did the work given properly and nicely.	Always appreciable and properly done	Created slide on time and put all interview answers in the DOC	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	Would you work with this Team member again?	Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Absolutely	You are very helpful and communicative.
Asadullah Imran	Absolutely	You are always responsible and hardworking.
Ibtida Ara	Absolutely	You always complete your work on time no matter what.

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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***
Absolutely, I think my team worked very hard and effectively. One of the main reasons I'd say is due to proper leadership and communication and helping each other always.

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***
No major issues to report. The team communicated well and any scheduling conflicts were handled responsibly, with the members catching up on their part afterward. Overall a smooth and collaborative group experience till now.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: _Sifatulah_____

Team Feedback Form

You MUST fill out this form by TYPING it or WE WILL NOT ACCEPT IT. Just open the form, type into it, save a copy for your records, then upload to the proper assignment location.
***Failure to turn in a feedback form OR failure to provide meaningful responses**, will result in a loss of 50% of your presentation grade. (for example: "good job!" is not acceptable feedback to provide to your teammates – provide real feedback with real examples! We will average the percentages that were awarded to you by your teammates and scale your project grad accordingly.*

YOUR Name: Ibtida Ara **Team: Orange(From Friend to Partner: Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions)**

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	Attendance	Dependability	Quality of Work	Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on	What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)
Ibtida Ara	Was present in every meeting & discussion	Did their work on time, and kept to deadlines & perform every tasks	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly	Helped to contribute in survey and draft interview questions,target population requirement fining,drafting follow up questions for interview ,read other papers to know drafting process and final drafting interview question answer session from audio	100
Sifatullah	Was present in every meeting & discussion	Did their work on time, and kept to deadlines & led the time nicely	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly all the time	Helped to lead group discussions and contributed in creating survey and interview questions	100
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Was present in every meeting & discussion	Did everything on time, and kept to deadlines & always collaborated	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly	Helped to contributed in creating survey and interview questions and survey result finding analysis	100
Asadullah Imran	Missed one meeting due to valid reason but able to make up the work	Did everything on time, and kept to deadlines & always collaborated	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly	Helped to contributed in affinity diagram to analysis the result of survey and interview	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	Would you work with this Team member again?	Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)

Sifatullah	Yes	*You did a great job leading our group discussions and keeping things organized. Your contributions to the survey and interview questions were solid, and you were always present and engaged. Keep up the strong leadership .*
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Yes	You were consistently reliable — always on time and collaborative. Your work on the survey/interview questions and the survey result analysis was thorough and well done. Great teammate to work with.
Asadullah Imran	Yes	You handled the affinity diagram and survey/interview result analysis very well, and even when you missed a meeting, you made sure to catch up on the work afterward. Appreciated the follow-through.
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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Yes, I feel our team worked effectively together. Everyone stayed on schedule, attended meetings regularly, and contributed meaningfully to different parts of the project — from survey and interview question design to affinity diagramming and result analysis. Clear task division and everyone's commitment to deadlines were really appreciateable .Overall, my experience working together till now has been really good,

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

No major issues to report. The team communicated well and any scheduling conflicts were handled responsibly, with the member catching up on their part afterward. Overall a smooth and collaborative group experience till now.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: _____Ibtida ara_____

Team Feedback Form

You MUST fill out this form by TYPING it or WE WILL NOT ACCEPT IT. Just open the form, type into it, save a copy for your records, then upload to the proper assignment location.
***Failure to turn in a feedback form OR failure to provide meaningful responses**, will result in a loss of 50% of your presentation grade. (for example: "good job!" is not acceptable feedback to provide to your teammates – provide real feedback with real examples! We will average the percentages that were awarded to you by your teammates and scale your project grad accordingly.*

YOUR Name: x(name) **Team:** X (INSERT TOPIC/TITLE OF YOUR PRESENTATION)

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	Attendance	Dependability	Quality of Work	Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on	What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)
Sifatullah	Attend every meeting	Did their work on time, kept to deadlines.	Every assigned task performed well.	Helped to lead the group discussion.	100
Jobayer Bin Kibria	attend every meeting	Did their work on time, kept to deadlines.	Every assigned task performed well.	Manage all the survey and the results.	100
Asadullah Imran	Missed one group online meeting due to Sickness.	Did their work on time, kept to deadlines.	Every assigned task performed well.	Performed affinity diagram	100
Ibtida Ara	Attend every meeting	Did their work on time, kept to deadlines.	Every assigned task performed well.	Perform methodology analysis.	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	Would you work with this Team member again?	Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)
Ibtida Ara	Yes.	she was good at delivery of the task
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Yes.	He was always helpful
Sifatullah	.Yes.	he was good at project manager

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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

I feel my team worked effectively together. To the project I contributed lots of brainstorming, literature review, interview, Affinity diagram. No right now i have no comments or concern about this projet.

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

As everything is doing great and we all four members are doing our task effectively so right now, there is nothing need to know.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: _____Asadullah Imran_____

Team Feedback Form

YOUR Name: Jobayer Bin Kibria **Team:** Orange

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

Team Member (list yourself!)	**Attendance**	**Dependability**	**Quality of Work**	**Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on**	**What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)**
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Was present in all meeting	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	Helped with the survey. And participated in the creation of the Interview question. Also informed about loopholes regarding survey or interview.	100
Asadullah Imran	Missed one but covered up the work perfectly	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	Helped with the Affinity diagram. Consistently worked and completed the task on time.	100
Ibtida Ara	Was present in all meeting	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	Helped to contribute in survey and interview questions. Along with spotting the target audiences and conducted interview.	100
Sifatullah	Was present in all meeting	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	Helped to contribute in survey and interview questions. Along with spotting the target audiences and conducted interview. Also led the group discussions and distributed works	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	**Would you work with this Team member again?**	**Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)**
Asadullah Imran	*YES*	*Superbly helpful. Always helped on time whenever stuck in a situation.*
Ibtida Ara	*YES*	Hardworking and consistent. Always looking for a better solution and clearly undestands the work.

Sifatullah	*YES*	Distributed and led the group works perfectly also helped whenever a teammate is stuck

PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Yes, I think my team worked very efficiently. Everyone was equally involved and worked with the same dedication. The teamwork and helpful nature is what led this team's first successful presentation. For now i think, if we keep up this consistency then something good will come.

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

For now, there weren't any complications. And the first stage of the paper was done quiet smoothly.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: Jobayer Bin Kibria